

Modern Apostles

prc-modern-apostles

Spiritual Gifts · Offices · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

The office of apostle in the foundational, Scripture-authoring sense (eyewitness of the risen Christ, sent with Christ's authority to lay the Church's foundation) was filled by the apostles of Christ and is not continuing today; claims to apostolic *office* in this sense after the apostolic age do not bind the Church's conscience, though missionary church-planting work that is sometimes called "apostolic" in a non-office sense is unaffected.

In plain language

The proposition limits itself to a narrow sense of 'apostle' (apostolos), the foundational, Scripture-bearing office held by the original group, and it explicitly grants that missionary work sometimes called apostolic is unaffected. On that narrow sense the words in Scripture line up. In Acts 1, when Judas is replaced, Peter sets two entrance requirements: the man must have accompanied the company during all the time the Lord Jesus went in and out among them, beginning from the baptism of John, and he must become a 'witness' (martyrs) of the 'resurrection' (anastasis). Those are first-generation criteria, datable and not repeatable. Paul defends his own standing in First Corinthians 9 with the question, 'have I not seen Jesus our Lord' (heoraka, from horao, 'to see'), using a perfect-tense verb (an action completed in the past whose result still stands) meaning a past sighting whose result still stands. In First Corinthians 15 Paul lists the resurrection appearances and says, 'last of all' (eschaton panton), as to 'one untimely born' (ektroma), 'he appeared also to me'. The phrase 'last of all' closes the appearance series and ranks Paul as the final eyewitness in this category. Ephesians 2 then calls the apostles and prophets the 'foundation' (themelios), with Christ as the 'cornerstone' (akrogoniaios), using building language in which a foundation is laid once and built upon, not added course by course. Revelation 21 fixes the picture: the city has 'twelve' (dodeka) foundations bearing the names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb. Jude says the faith was 'once for all delivered' (hapax paradotheise) to the saints, using a word that means once for all. Confidence is medium rather than high because the very same Greek word, 'apostle' (apostolos), is used in a wider everyday sense of a sent envoy or delegate, as with Epaphroditus in Philippians 2 and the 'apostles of the churches' (apostoloi ekklesion) in Second Corinthians 8. Ephesians 4 also lists apostles in a gift list without specifying whether the gift continues. So the lexical root-cause of the divergence is straightforward: 'apostle' (apostolos) carries two attested senses, one bounded by the eyewitness criteria of Acts 1 and First Corinthians 15, and one a broader sent-one usage. Readers who restrict the question to the bounded sense agree the office closed; readers who collapse the two senses, or who lean on Ephesians 4 without the Ephesians 2 foundation framing, will read continuation. The proposition picks the bounded sense and the lexical pattern supports it.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H3808	אֵל	lo	not	

H5030	נָבִי	nabi	prophet	305
G0204	ἀκρογωνιαίος	akrogoniaios	cornerstone	2
G0386	ἀνάστασις	anastasis	resurrection	42
G0530	ἅπαξ	hapax	once	14
G0652	ἀπόστολος	apostolos	apostle	80
G0721	ἀρνίον	arnion	lamb	31
G1163	δεῖ	dei	be necessary	106
G1427	δώδεκα	dodeka	twelve	81
G1525	εἰσερχομαι	eiserchomai	to enter	
G1626	ἐκτρωμα	ektroma	untimely birth	1
G1831	ἐξερχομαι	exerchomai	to go out	
G2026	ἐποικοδομέω	epoikodomeo	to build up/upon	7
G2078	ἐσχάτος	eschatos	last/least	52
G2310	θεμέλιος	themelios	foundation	16
G3144	μάρτυς	martys	witness	35
G3708	ὁράω	horao	to see	61
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidomi	to deliver	121

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The proposition restricts itself to the foundational, Scripture-authoring apostolic office and explicitly carves out the broader sent-one (apostolos) usage. On that narrow sense the lexical pattern lines up. Acts 1:21-22 sets two entrance criteria: companionship of Jesus through the whole earthly ministry, and being a witness (martys) of the resurrection (anastasis). 1 Corinthians 9:1 grounds Paul's claim in 'I have seen' (heoraka), the perfect (a completed action whose result still stands) of 'to see' (horao), a past sighting whose result still stands. 1 Corinthians 15:8 then places Paul as 'last of all' (eschaton de panton), like an 'untimely birth' (ektroma), presenting the resurrection-appearance line as a closed series. Ephesians 2:20 calls the apostles and prophets the foundation (themelios), with Christ as cornerstone (akrogoniaios), and Revelation 21:14 fixes the city wall at twelve foundations (themelious) bearing the twelve apostles' names. Jude 1:3 names the faith as 'once for all delivered' (hapax paradotheise). Confidence is medium not high because 'apostle' (apostolos) itself is polysemous (carries multiple senses) in the canon (Philippians 2:25 Epaphroditus, 2 Corinthians 8:23 'apostles of the churches' (apostoloi ekklesion), Romans 16:7) and Ephesians 4:11 lists 'apostles' (apostolous) in a gift list without lexically marking duration, so the words alone do not foreclose a non-foundational continuing usage; the verdict holds because the proposition explicitly limits itself to the foundational sense.

Scripture

Acts.1.21 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1163 δεῖ, G1525 εἰσέρχομαι, G1831 ἐξέρχομαι

Reasoning. Peter sets the necessity, 'it is necessary' (dei), that the replacement be from among the men who were with the company 'in all the time the Lord Jesus went in and out among us' (en panti chrono ho eiselthen kai exelthen eph hemas ho kyrios Iesous), beginning from the baptism of John. The 'went in' (eiselthen) and 'went out' (exelthen) aorist (a completed past action) pair is a finite, datable window of personal accompaniment that cannot be re-entered after the apostolic generation.

Acts.1.22 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3144 μάρτυς, G0386 ἀνάστασις

Reasoning. The candidate must become 'a witness with us of his resurrection' (martura tes anastaseos autou syn hemin), 'witness' (martyr) and 'resurrection' (anastasis). The defining content of the office is firsthand testimony to the risen Christ. The criterion is personal sensory eyewitness, which forecloses any candidate who did not see the risen Lord.

1Cor.9.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0652 ἀπόστολος, G3708 ὁράω

Reasoning. Paul stakes his apostleship (apostolos) on 'have I not seen Jesus our Lord' (ouchi Iesoun ton kurion hemon heoraka). 'I have seen' (heoraka) is the perfect active (a completed action whose result still stands) of 'to see' (horao), a past act of seeing whose effect abides. Paul uses the same grammatical move that Acts 1:22 demands of any candidate, attesting that the lexical entrance criterion is consistent across the eyewitness apostolate (the body of apostles).

1Cor.15.8 · for · genre: epistle · figures: simile

Key terms. G2078 ἔσχατος, G1626 ἔκτρωμα

Reasoning. Paul lists the resurrection appearances and at the end says 'last of all, as to one untimely born, he appeared also to me' (eschaton de panton hosperei to ektromati ophthe kamoi). 'Last of all' (eschaton panton) presents the post-resurrection appearance series as a closed enumeration. 'Untimely birth' (ektroma) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) in the New Testament that marks Paul's appearance as out-of-sequence and final. The vocabulary itself ranks Paul as the last witness in this category, which is the strongest lexical case that the eyewitness apostolate (the body of apostles) is a bounded series and not a continuing one.

Eph.2.20 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος, G0204 ἀκρογωνιαίος, G2026 ἐποικοδομέω

Reasoning. Believers are 'built up on the foundation of the apostles and prophets' (epoikodomethentes epi to themelio ton apostolon kai propheton), Christ Jesus being 'the cornerstone' (akrogoniaiou). 'Having been built up' (epoikodomethentes) is an aorist (a completed past action) passive participle, a completed action of being built up. 'Foundation' (themelios) in construction language is what is laid first and once and then built upon. 'Cornerstone' (akrogoniaios) is itself near-hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) (only Ephesians 2:20 and 1 Peter 2:6, both christological, that is, referring to Christ). The architecture argues for a non-repeating base layer.

Rev.21.14 · for · genre: apocalyptic · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος, G1427 δώδεκα, G0721 ἄρνιον

Reasoning. The wall of the city has 'twelve foundations and on them the twelve names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb' (themelious dodeka kai ep auton dodeka onomata ton dodeka apostolon tou arniou). The number 'twelve' (dodeka) is fixed and recurs three times in the verse for the foundations, names, and apostles, presenting the foundational apostolate (the body of apostles) as a closed and enumerated set rather than an open continuing office.

Jude.1.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0530 ἅπαξ, G3860 παραδίδωμι

Reasoning. The faith is described as 'the faith once for all delivered to the saints' (tei hapax paradotheisei tois hagiois pistei). 'Once for all' (hapax) in this usage means once for all, decisively and not to be repeated (compare Hebrews 9:26-28 of Christ's offering, 1 Peter 3:18 of his death). 'Having been delivered' (paradotheise) is an aorist (a completed past action) passive participle of 'to hand over' (paradidomi), a completed act of handover. A deposit handed over once for all (hapax) cannot be re-delivered, which closes the foundational, deposit-bearing office that delivered it.

Deut.18.22 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H5030 נביא, H3808 אל

Reasoning. The test of a true 'prophet' (nabi) is whether the word comes to pass; if not, 'the LORD has not spoken it' (lo dibbero YHWH). Scripture sets an objective verification criterion for claimed bearers of divine authority. By analogy of Scripture (interpreting Scripture by Scripture) this weighs against unverified claims to a foundational, Scripture-bearing office.

Rom.16.7 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0652 ἀπόστολος

Reasoning. Andronicus and Junia are 'notable among the apostles' (episemoi en tois apostolois). The phrase is grammatically ambiguous between 'of note among the apostles' (inclusive sense) and 'well known to the apostles' (exclusive sense). Either way the word 'apostle' (apostolos) here is either the broad sent-one sense or denotes recognition by the apostles, not predication of the foundational eyewitness office of Acts 1:21-22.

Phil.2.25 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0652 ἀπόστολος

Reasoning. Paul calls Epaphroditus 'your apostle and minister of my need' (humon de apostolon kai leitourgon tes chreias mou). Here 'apostle' (apostolos) plainly carries the broad sent-one or delegate sense, a commissioned envoy from a local assembly, not a foundational Scripture-authoring office. This is a clear datapoint that 'apostle' (apostolos) is polysemous (carries multiple senses) in the canon.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Eph.2.20	Eph.4.11	tsk	1
Eph.2.20	Isa.28.16	tsk	1
Eph.2.20	1Pet.2.6	tsk	1
Rev.21.14	Rev.21.19	tsk	1
1Cor.9.1	1Cor.15.8	tsk	1
Acts.1.22	Acts.1.8	tsk	1
Acts.1.22	Acts.10.41	tsk	1
Jude.1.3	Heb.9.26	tsk	1
Deut.18.22	Deut.18.20	tsk	1
Deut.18.22	Deut.13.2	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Eph.4.11 · addressed

Christ 'gave some as apostles' (kai edoken tous men apostolous), alongside prophets, evangelists, shepherds and teachers, for the equipping of the saints. The verb 'gave' (didomi) is aorist (a completed past action) and does not lexically encode duration. The list names a gift but does not specify whether the office continues or is bounded. The same letter at Ephesians 2:20 already calls the apostles and prophets the foundation, which is the lexical resource that anchors the boundedness for the Scripture-authoring sense. The words alone leave room for a continuing non-foundational reading of 'apostle' (apostolos) here, which is the main reason confidence on the broader question is medium rather than high.

2Cor.8.23 · addressed

Paul calls envoys 'apostles of the churches' (apostoloi ekklesion). The genitive (the 'of-X' grammatical form) 'of the churches' (ekklēsia) shows that 'apostle' (apostolos) here is a representative or delegate of local congregations, not a Scripture-authoring eyewitness office. This is direct lexical evidence that 'apostle' (apostolos) carries a non-technical congregational sense in the same author who applies the technical sense to himself, demonstrating polysemy (multiple senses).

Rom.16.7 · addressed

Andronicus and Junia are 'notable among the apostles' (episemoi en tois apostolois). Either reading (notable among them, or well known to them) keeps the term away from the foundational eyewitness criteria; neither reading predicates Acts 1:21-22 companionship plus resurrection eyewitness of these individuals.

Phil.2.25 · addressed

Epaphroditus is 'your apostle' (hūmon apostolos), 'your sent one', the broad delegate sense. The stem itself explicitly carves out this non-office missionary use as unaffected, so this datapoint does not falsify the proposition.

2Cor.12.12 · addressed

Paul speaks of 'the signs of the apostle' (ta semeia tou apostolou), worked among the Corinthians in patience with signs, wonders and powers. The genitive (the 'of-X' grammatical form) 'of the apostle' (tou apostolou) treats 'apostle' (apostolos) as a recognizable category with attesting signs. This text does not foreclose the foundational reading; rather, it gives the office authenticating marks. Whether such signs accompany only the foundational generation or could recur is not settled by this verse's words alone.

1Cor.15.7 · addressed

Then he appeared to James, 'then to all the apostles' (eita tois apostolois pasin). The use of the article (the word 'the') 'to all the apostles' (tois apostolois pasin) presents a definite, enumerable group already in view by 50s AD, after which 1 Corinthians 15:8 places Paul as 'last' (eschaton). The 'all' (pasin) closes the set.

Concordance traversed

G0652, G3708, G2310, G0204, G2026, G0386, G3144, G1163, G0530, G3860, G1427, G0721, G2078, G1626, H5030, H3808

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The bundle reports not_in_ecm_scope (not within the scope of the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) true with an empty variant_units list. The cited verses (Acts 1:21-22, 1 Corinthians 9:1, 1 Corinthians 15:8, Ephesians 2:20, Jude 1:3, Revelation 21:14, Deuteronomy 18:21-22) carry no verdict-bearing variant in the supplied apparatus, and the load-bearing terms ('apostle' (apostolos), 'foundation' (themelios), 'once for all' (hapax), 'twelve' (dodeka), 'it is necessary' (dei), 'resurrection' (anastasis), 'I have seen' (heoraka), 'untimely birth' (ektroma)) are textually stable across the tradition.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play: cessationism, continuationism, restorationism, broad-sent-one-only

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

cessationism: affirms · Reads Acts 1:21-22 eyewitness criterion, 1 Corinthians 9:1 'I have seen' (heoraka), 1 Corinthians 15:8 'last of all' (eschaton panton) and 'untimely birth' (ektroma), Ephesians 2:20 foundation language, Revelation 21:14 closed twelve, and Jude 1:3 'once for all delivered' (hapax paradotheise) as jointly closing the foundational office with the apostolic generation. The construction-grammar of the foundation metaphor and the bounded series of resurrection appearances are the strongest lexical features.

continuationism: affirms with qualification · Often grants that the foundational eyewitness Scripture-authoring office closed (Acts 1:21-22 cannot be re-entered, 1 Corinthians 15:8 'last' (eschaton) is decisive) while holding that gift-list 'apostle' (apostolos) in Ephesians 4:11 and the sent-one usage in 2 Corinthians 8:23 and Philippians 2:25 are real continuing functions. On the strict scope of the proposition this lens is compatible with affirms because the proposition limits itself to the foundational sense and explicitly carves out missionary apostolic work.

restorationism: denies · Claims a restored governing apostolic office today, often grounding the case on Ephesians 4:11 (apostles in the gift list with no stated duration), 2 Corinthians 12:12 (signs of an apostle as a recurring category marker), and a non-bounded reading of the broader 'apostle' (apostolos) uses. In its strongest lexical form, this lens argues that Acts 1:21-22 sets criteria only for the replacement of Judas in the original Twelve and does not legislate apostle-criteria for all generations, and that 1 Corinthians 15:8 'last' (eschaton) refers to the resurrection-appearance series specifically and not to apostolic office per se. The lens has to reckon with the foundation-metaphor of Ephesians 2:20 and Revelation 21:14 twelve, but reads them as historical descriptors of the founding group rather than a fixed cap.

broad-sent-one-only: denies (in a different sense) · A reading that takes 'apostle' (apostolos) in its etymological breadth (one sent, from 'to send' (apostello)) and resists ranking any New Testament use as a special office. On this lens, Paul, the Twelve, Epaphroditus, and the 'apostles of the churches' (apostoloi ekklesion) of 2 Corinthians 8:23 all participate in the same fundamental category, distinguished only by mission scope. Such a reading would deny that the office in the foundational sense ever existed as a separate category, but it must account for the explicit Acts 1:21-22 criteria and 1 Corinthians 15:8 'last' (eschaton), which mark out a distinguishable bounded set.

Verdict turns on the grammatical force of the perfect (a completed action whose result still stands) 'I have seen' (heoraka) and 'he appeared' (ophthe), the aorist (a completed past action) passive participles 'having been built up' (epoikodomethentes) and 'having been delivered' (paradotheise), the closed-series adverb 'last of all' (eschaton) with the hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) 'untimely birth' (ektroma), the once-for-all force of 'once for all' (hapax), and the architectural metaphor of 'foundation' (themelios) and 'cornerstone' (akrogoniaios). The polysemy (multiple senses) of 'apostle' (apostolos) is the main reason confidence is medium rather than high.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does Scripture's vocabulary present the office of apostle (as the term is used of the Twelve and Paul) as a foundational, bounded category that closed with the apostolic generation, or as a continuing office that can be filled today, and how does it relate to the broader sent-one ('apostle' (apostolos)) usage in the New Testament?

The stem builds in a distinction between a foundational, Scripture-authoring eyewitness office and non-office missionary work, and pre-classifies the latter as unaffected. That framing leans toward affirms by isolating the strongest closed case (foundational eyewitness) and exempting the easier polysemy (multiple senses) case (sent-one). The verdict was derived on the original stem; the neutralized form poses the question without pre-resolving the foundational versus continuing split, and lets the lexical data speak both to the bounded Acts 1:21-22 plus 1 Corinthians 15:8 series and to the polysemy in Philippians 2:25 plus 2 Corinthians 8:23.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.9.1

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.15.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.1.22
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.20
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0652
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0530
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2310
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1626
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3708
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.18.22
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5030
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Eph.2.20
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rev.21.14
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.9.1

License audit

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MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
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(none)